The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Israel began a new wave of “extensive strikes” on **Iranian** infrastructure. Earlier it announced it had killed a commander of the Quds Force, the foreign arm of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, who reportedly co-ordinated with **Hizbullah** in Lebanon. Meanwhile America said it had struck nearly 2,000 targets in Iran since war broke out. It also released the names of four soldiers killed in a drone attack in Kuwait.

Donald Trump said America would “immediately” provide insurance for shipping lines travelling through the **Strait of Hormuz**, a vital trade route that Iran declared closed on Monday, and that the navy would escort oil tankers if necessary. America’s president also said he had ordered the attack on Iran because he believed it would strike first—contradicting Marco Rubio, the secretary of state, who said on Monday that America had feared retaliation in response to a planned Israeli attack. Mr Trump also said he would sever trade ties with Spain after the country denied America access to its military bases.

A mass funeral was held for pupils and teachers killed by what Iran says was an American missile strike on a girls’ school in **Minat**. Iranian authorities say that 165 people were killed. America’s

Central Command said it was looking into reports that a school was hit. In Dubai, meanwhile, the American consulate was set ablaze after reportedly being hit by an Iranian drone.

Oil prices continued to soar while **Asian stocks** fell steeply again on Wednesday. On Tuesday Britain's FTSE 100 index fell by 3% and America's S&P 500 closed down by almost 1%. Rising oil and gas prices have stoked fears of inflation, pushing up global bond yields and reducing traders' expectations of interest-rate cuts.

China's purchasing manufacturing index, a gauge of producer sentiment, fell to a four-month low of 49.0 in February. That is down from 49.3 in January (anything below 50 indicates contraction). China's National Bureau of Statistics blamed an unusually long lunar new year holiday. The unwelcome news comes as China's rubber-stamp parliament convenes to decide economic targets for the coming year.

OpenAI's boss, Sam Altman, said the artificial-intelligence company would change a deal it struck with America's Department of War to limit the use of its tools to surveil Americans. The two parties reached the agreement shortly after the Trump administration banned federal agencies from using the technology of Anthropic, a rival AI lab, because it refused to allow its products to be used for mass domestic surveillance.

Around 507m children aged five to 19 will be **obese or overweight** by 2040, according to the World Obesity Foundation, up from 419m currently. That represents 26% of the age group, compared with around 21% today. WOF estimates that at least 120m school-age children will show early signs of chronic disease caused by their weight. Low- and middle-income countries are seeing the fastest growth in obesity rates.

Figure of the day: Six percentage points, the polling lead that Tisza, a Hungarian opposition party, had over Viktor Orban's

Fidesz as of February 27th. Follow the race for April's elections on our tracker.

Photograph: Marijan Murat/dpa

An unfolding energy nightmare

Energy analysts modelling a war involving Iran have long feared two developments: the Islamic Republic lashing out at its oil-rich neighbours and a blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, through which a third of global seaborne crude and a fifth of liquefied natural gas transit daily.

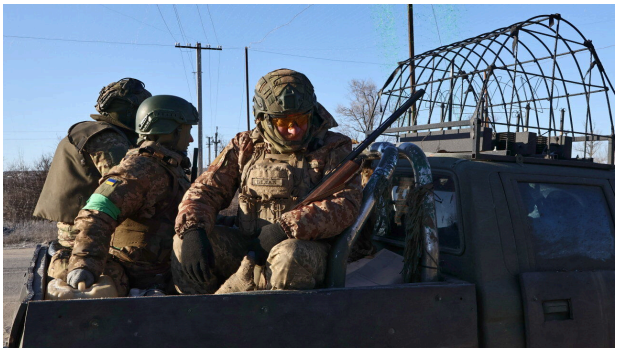
Now both are happening at once. Iran has struck energy facilities in Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, Iran's praetorian guard, have declared Hormuz closed and vessels have been hit. As a result, energy prices are catching fire. Iraq is running out of storage for its stranded oil and cutting output; Kuwait may follow. Asian buyers are already turning elsewhere to replace the oil and gas they no longer get from the Gulf, pushing up prices for everyone. It is unclear whether Donald Trump's promise of insurance and naval escorts for tankers in the Gulf will do much to get oil flowing again. The economic consequences of the energy shock could be far-reaching.

Photograph: Getty Images

Iran’s new power struggle

American and Israeli bombardment and an internet blackout make it difficult to read public opinion in Iran. The regime is still widely loathed. But as bombs fall dissent has retreated indoors. On Iran’s streets mourning for Ayatollah Ali Khamenei—killed on Saturday—has eclipsed grief for the thousands of protesters slain in January at his command.

A worn-out regime has found renewed purpose under fire. Anti-Americanism and anti-Zionism, which had become threadbare ideologies, have gained fresh force. The restraints that Khamenei placed on Iran’s armed forces are off. And political hardliners, emboldened by war, appear to have replaced reformists in the struggle to name Khamenei’s successor as supreme leader. Talk of a managed transition—or of repairing the rupture with America that has defined the regime since 1979—has faded. The leading contender is Alireza Arafi, a cleric groomed by Khamenei who once ran a seminary devoted to training foreign students to export the revolution.



Photograph: AP

How the Iran war hurts Ukraine

Ukraine’s president, Volodymyr Zelensky, expects trilateral talks with America and Russia to go ahead this week despite the outbreak of war in the Middle East. Iran’s regime is an ally of the Kremlin and has supplied drone technology to Russia’s armed forces. But the war could have negative consequences for Ukraine. Higher oil prices will bring some relief to Russia’s hard-pressed economy. And the need for American air-defence interceptors by Israel and America’s Gulf allies will mean that fewer are available for Ukraine.

Even so, things are going a bit better for Ukraine on the battlefield. The head of its armed forces, Oleksandr Syrsky, claims that his troops retook more territory in February than Russia captured. The coming of spring should bring some relief to civilians whom Russia has tried to freeze into submission through relentless strikes on Ukraine’s power grid. Progress at the talks, however, is highly unlikely.

Photograph: Getty Images

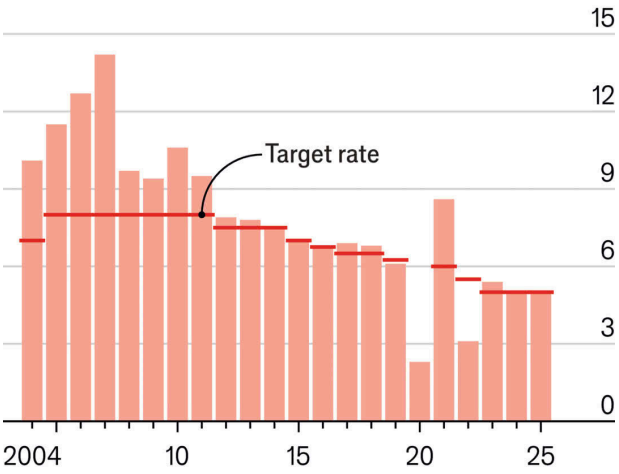
China’s rubber-stamp parliament convenes

This week China’s “two sessions”, the annual meeting of its legislature, the National People’s Congress, and that of its advisory body, kick off in Beijing. Li Qiang, the prime minister, will set out the country’s goals for the coming year to 2,900-odd delegates at the NPC on Thursday. He may trim China’s annual GDP growth target from “around 5%” (as it has been for the past three years) to 4.5-5%, amid a lingering property slump.

China’s next five-year plan, which will cover the period from 2026 to 2030, will also be released during the NPC session, which usually lasts around a week, for delegates to give their approval. It will set out guidance for officials on everything under the sun, from encouraging China’s cautious consumers to spend more, to boosting birth rates. But the focus will be achieving self-sufficiency in technologies where it still relies on foreign equipment or know-how, such as semiconductors and aircraft engines.

Where to next?

China, GDP, % increase on a year earlier



Sources: LSEG Workspace; Bloomberg

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Arturo Toscanini, Leopold Stokowski and Claudio Abbado all achieved fame in what role?

Tuesday: Which book by Nate Silver, published in 2012, is about the art of interpreting statistics?

You have to be slightly blind to believe in any cause.

Elizabeth Smart